

College of Engineering and Information Technology

Flying Radar: A Drone-Based Software-Defined Radar

Commercial In Confidence

ENGI 4900: Final Report

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36/36 Pages

Summary of AI Use

Categories of artificial intelligence (AI) tool use in this assignment are as indicated in the following table.

AI tool use category	Used
Spelling	✓
Grammar	✓
Other copy editing	
Literature review support	
Visuals	
Substantive editing	
Idea generation	
Translation	
Research technical support	✓
No AI tool was used	

Acknowledgements

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List of Acronyms

Acronym	Definition
3D	three dimensional
AC	alternating current
AI	artificial intelligence
API	application programming interface
ASA	acrylonitrile styrene acrylate
AST	Advanced Systems & Technologies
CLI	command-line interface
CPU	central processing unit
C-UAS	counter-uncrewed aerial system
CAD	computer-aided design
COTS	commercial off-the-shelf
CW	continuous wave
DC	direct current
DEM	digital elevation model
FMCW	frequency modulated continuous wave
GPIO	general purpose input/output
GPR	ground penetrating radar
GPS	global positioning system
HALE	high-altitude long-endurance
IDE	integrated development environment
IED	improvised explosive device
InSAR	interferometric synthetic aperture radar
IQ	in-phase and quadrature
JSON	JavaScript Object Notation

JST	Japan solderless terminal
LiPo	lithium-polymer
PCB	printed circuit board
PID	product identifier
PLA	polylactic acid
PWM	pulse-width modulation
RC	radio control
RF	radio frequency
SAR	synthetic aperture radar
SBC	single-board computer
SD	secure digital
SDR	software-defined radar
SI	International System of Units
SLD	single-line diagram
SSH	secure shell
UAV	uncrewed aerial vehicle
USB	universal serial bus
VID	vendor identifier

Contribution Statement

This contribution statement records the specific contribution of each team member to the technical work and preparation of this progress report. Contributions are grouped according to the simplified CRediT categories of Approach, Technical output, Writing, and Project management.

Table CS1: Declaration of group contributions to the report.

Author	Team Role	Approach	Technical Output	Writing	Project Management

Table CS2: Acknowledgement of AI Tool Use

Group member name	Specific sub-sections or paragraphs where AI was used	AI Tool Use Category/ies
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Table CS3: Group Member Comments

Group member name	Comments
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By signing below students are acknowledging that the contributions recorded above are a true representation of the contribution made by each individual.

Table CS4: Signature Acknowledgement of Contribution

Name	Student ID	Signature
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4 Methods, Results and Discussion

4.1 Objective 4: Synchronise Logging of Flight Telemetry and Radar Measurements

4.1.1 Introduction

To synchronise flight telemetry and radar measurements, a pilot-initiated control signal must be interpreted, processed, and transmitted through the system. The signal travels from the pilot transmitter to the receiver, then to the flight controller, and finally to the single-board computer (SBC), which triggers SDR logging. This signal path is shown in Figure 4.1.

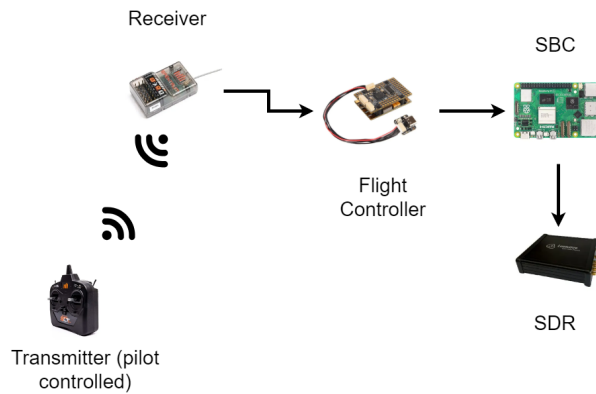
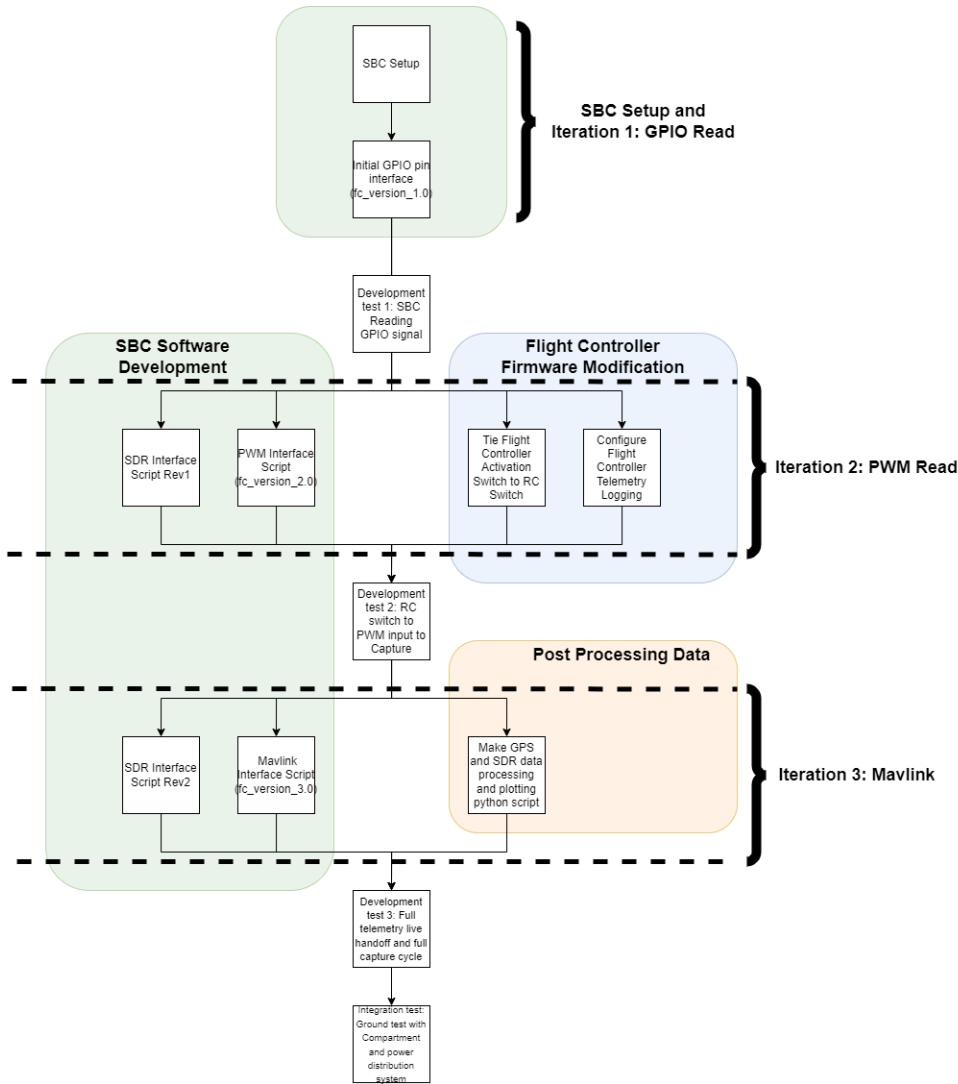


Figure 4.1: Activation signal flow starting at the pilot transmitter and ending at the SDR.

Progress toward this objective has included researching and procuring a suitable SBC, completing its initial setup, and conducting a communication trial between the SBC and a simulated flight-controller signal.

4.1.2 Methodology



Hardware and Setup

First, requirements of the SBC were identified. The hardware requirements for the SBC were derived from the SDR datasheet, which specifies the need for a high-speed USB 2.0 interface (480 Mb/s) [?]. Additionally, the SBC should provide sufficient processing capability to support potential future expansion of onboard processing capability, placing requirements on CPU performance and RAM capacity. Consequently, a Raspberry Pi 5 with 16 GB of RAM was selected and procured. In addition to satisfying the hardware requirements, Raspberry Pi devices were selected because of their well-supported software ecosystem and prior use in drone-mounted radar research applications [?, ?, ?, ?]. A protective case and active cooler were also acquired to secure the device on board the drone and manage central processing unit (CPU) temperature during SDR operation.

The Raspberry Pi 5 was physically assembled and configured with a lightweight Ubuntu 22.04 operating system. The installation process used an imager to write the Ubuntu disk image to a 64 GB microSD card. The card was then inserted into the Raspberry Pi 5, and the system was booted to verify the operating-system installation. A remote development workflow was then configured to develop and test the Python script used to read the general purpose input/output (GPIO) pin. Native development on the Raspberry Pi was avoided due to its lower performance

compared with a desktop computer. Instead, secure shell (SSH) was configured and integrated with an integrated development environment (IDE) to enable remote development. The setup commands are shown in Appendix A.1. To allow the Raspberry Pi to read GPIO pins, the required GPIO packages were installed. The setup commands are shown in Appendix A.2. The virtual environment setup and installation of `rpi-lgpio` is shown in Appendix A.3. After installing the packages, a Python script was created to read a GPIO pin and respond when an external component pulls the signal high. The script is shown in Appendix A.4. To verify the program, an Arduino Uno R3 was used to generate an input signal for a GPIO pin. Because the Raspberry Pi 5 uses 3.3 V logic and the Arduino Uno R3 outputs 5 V logic, a resistor divider was used to reduce the signal to approximately 3.3 V and protect the Raspberry Pi.

Development Approach

After the first software iteration was tested and confirmed working as expected, a new iteration was created. This iteration now reads in the specific signal sent from the flight controller output to the GPIO pins, which is pulse-width modulation (PWM). This iteration was split into several parallel tasks. On the flight controller side, outputting a specific PWM channel from an activation switch on the transmitter was a task, as was configuring the flight controller for telemetry logging. On the SBC side, a refined script to interface with the flight controllers signals was made, and setting up the SBC to interface with the Radar (including the function to run the SDR capture and setting up the software requirements to run the SDR) was it's own task. These four tasks are outlined in this section.

At this stage of development, the flight controller interfaces with the SBC via PWM. Whether a signal is logic HIGH or logic LOW is determined by the pulse width of the transmission. For the flight controller signal, a pulse width below 1300 μs is logic LOW, and a pulse width above 1700 μs is logic HIGH. This is the logic embedded into the script that the SBC uses to interface with the flight controller.

Flight Controller Configuration

Before doing anything, the flight controller had to be connected to a Desktop PC to be able to interface with the device properly. This was done by installing and using Mission Planner. Upon configuring, the task then became to tie a PWM output channel to an RC switch on the transmitter. This PWM output channel would then be read by the SBC, which would activate/deactivate the radar capture accordingly.

On the transmitter in possession, there were 8 physical switches. The switch that was deemed suitable was tied to RC channel 15 using the transmitter settings. In Mission Planner, RC Channel 15 was then tied to servo output 8. After configuring, the output signal was scoped with an oscilloscope and confirmed working as intended. This development concluded with a successful tying of the transmitter physical switch to a servo output channel on the flight controller, enabling the transmitter to have a physical switch dedicated to radar capture.

It was also imperative to gain an understanding of how the flight controller recorded telemetry and configure the logging in such a way to suit the application. That was the objective of this section. It was found that when the host PC connects to the flight controller, the flight controller makes a .tlog file and continues to write to the .tlog file until the connection is terminated. The telemetry log only records global positioning system (GPS) when the drone is armed. This setting did not suit the project, as the drone needed to be disarmed for the majority of the project. To enable GPS logging while disarmed, a parameter was changed in the config file in

Mission Planner.

Final System

Likewise from the second iteration, a single python 3 program on the SBC handled both the flight controller and the SDR in one loop.

Again, the code was split by device, a `Drone` class, which handled the flight controller interface, a `Radar` class, which handled the radar interface, and a small `main.py` script to run the overall program.

The benefit to the program being one system was the fact that all the timing was able to use a single clock, which was `runtime` (seconds elapsed since the start of the program). Both the telemetry log and the radar used this value, and shared the same time base which is what made synchronisation possible.

Mavlink Interface

The SBC interfaced with the drone via Mavlink, a communication protocol used to interface between flight controllers and desktop computers (which the Raspberry Pi 5 running Ubuntu has a similar architecture to). The physical connection was over universal serial bus (USB) serial, and the software interface was handled by the `pymavlink` python package.

The script blocked until it received a `HEARTBEAT` signal which confirmed the link and gave the target system and component IDs to be used by later commands. Instead of relying on default stream rates, the script sent `MAV_CMD_SET_MESSAGE_INTERVAL` commands to request each message at a fixed rate. The message ID's of the key messages is shown in Table 4.1.

Table 4.1: MAVLink messages requested from the flight controller and their use.

Message	ID	Rate	Used for
GPS_RAW_INT	24	1 Hz	Fix type, satellites, latitude, longitude
GLOBAL_POSITION_INT	33	5 Hz	Altitude (AMSL and relative), groundspeed
ATTITUDE	30	5 Hz	Roll, pitch, yaw
BATTERY_STATUS	147	1 Hz	Voltage, current, remaining capacity
VFR_HUD	74	2 Hz	Requested but not parsed
RC_CHANNELS	65	5 Hz	Channel 15 (radar trigger)
HEARTBEAT	0	Default	Armed state, flight mode

on each loop in the `main.py` file, `update()` drained every queued message with non blocking `recv_match(blocking=False)`, and so the program was never stalled by a slow link as the stored value was always the latest received.

Raw Mavlink fields were converted to International System of Units (SI) units upon reception, including converting latitude and longitude from degE7 to degrees, altitude from millimetres to metres, and voltage from millivolts to volts.

The armed status of the drone was read from the `MAV_MODE_FLAG_SAFETY_ARMED` bit of `HEARTBEAT.base_mode`, and the flight mode was decoded with `mode_string_v10`. The `gps_ready` state was changed based on whether a fix to three or more satellites was present.

Same from iteration 2, the radar was triggered from a switch on the pilot's transmitter which was mapped to channel 15. However, instead of reading in a PWM signal output from the flight controller, the signal was read through the `RC_CHANNELS` MAVlink message.

The trigger logic remained the same; rising edge detection. A capture was requested by the main

script to the radar only when the pulse width was above 1800 μs . The capture logic was sticky; the switch had to be seen as low before a new capture could be requested (which was a pulse width below 1200 μs). The sticky logic prevented one switch from firing repeatedly, ignored the noise in the invalid range, and prevented a switch left high at startup from requesting a capture. Both pulse width parameters can be changed easily in the config file. Buffering was not used; if the radar was still busy, the request was rejected and a message printed, instead of the request being queued. The reason for this was predictability; the timespan of the radar capture is too long for buffering to be feasible.

The previous iteration used a GPIO activation signal from the flight controller. This was replaced in iteration 3 with reading the radio control (RC) channel directly through MAVLink. Doing this simplified physical wiring greatly as with MAVLink all communication is handled over a single USB connection. The GPIO activation signal was also dependent on the safety switch status of the drone; it had to be off for an output to occur. This issue is not present in the MAVLink setup.

On each script startup a telemetry log in the form of a .csv file was created from the program, named with the start date and time, so that a telemetry log never overwrote a previous log. Each row in the log held sixteen telemetry fields and five radar fields of data, in addition to the program runtime. Among the five radar fields was the file name of the radar capture (if one occurred), so that each radar capture could be matched directly to the telemetry rows.

To view live data for verification and testing, a terminal dashboard (which was viewed over SSH) showed flight state, GPS, attitude, battery voltage, the pulse width of the RC channel tied to the activation of the SDR, and the radar status. The display was refreshed at one Hz; a parameter changable in the config file.

SDR Interface

The SBC and radar did not communicate directly. Insead, the capture executable file was ran by the **radar** class in the program as a subprocess. This was to ensure appropriate seperation between the two systems in order to minimise complexity. Under this method, the SBC was only responsible for scheduling and bookkeeping of the radar captures.

The capture settings for the radar existed in a JavaScript Object Notation (JSON) file which was read by the program at startup, so that parameters could change between flights without editing code. Among these settings were the executable and firmware paths, output folder for the radar captures, duration of capture, and sweep time.

[Capture sequence as a state machine. Will be changed in code so write here after that's done]

Each capture file was named according to its capture number and runtime on capture. Together with the per-row radar columns in the CSV file, this gave two independent ways to align the radar capture data with the telemetry data sets.

Post-Processing

4.1.3 Results and Discussion

Development test 1: GPIO Read

Development test 2: RC Switch to PWM Capture Cycle

Development test 3: Full telemetry live handoff and full capture cycle

Ground Test: Full Integration with other subsystems on the ground demonstrating full capture cycle and logging

4.1.4 Summary

Statement of AI Use

Spelling and Grammar

The project team used ChatGPT (<https://chat.openai.com/>) and Claude (<https://claude.ai/>) for this Progress Report to check spelling and grammar in selected text drafted by the team. The use of AI tool was limited to identifying spelling and grammar errors. The tools were not used to draft new report sections, produce summaries or paraphrases, restructure the report, interpret results, draw conclusions. The project team reviewed all suggestions before making any changes and retained copies of the original text submitted to the AI tools.

The following prompt was used in May 2026:

Please review the following paragraph and identify spelling and grammar errors only. Do not rewrite the text, change the meaning, improve the flow, shorten sentences, add content, or make style or substantive editing suggestions.

Initials of group members who used this support: HL, LT, KM, AS.

Research Technical Support

The project team used Claude Code to analyse the legacy MATLAB driver, implement radar commands, and produce code documentation. All code and documentation generated by AI underwent human review and approval. AI use in this form was approved verbally by Dr Brian Ng. The following prompt was used in April 2026:

Document all functions in the following file using Doxygen-style comments:

`C:\Users\eliza\SDR_main\SDR_main\linux\src\UsbDevice.cpp`

Documentation requirements:

- Add a Doxygen comment block above every function definition.
- Include:
 - `@brief`
 - `@param` for all parameters
 - `@return` where applicable
 - `@note` or `@warning` if relevant
- Keep descriptions concise but technically clear.

Initials of group members who used this support: HL

A Objective 4: Supporting Material

A.1 SSH Setup

Listing A.1: The commands used to setup SSH connection between the Raspberry Pi and a remote computer.

```
1 sudo apt install openssh-server
2 sudo systemctl enable ssh
3 sudo ufw allow ssh
```

A.2 GPIO Packages Install

Listing A.2: Bash command used to install python GPIO library.

```
1 sudo apt install python3-lgpio gpiod
```

A.3 Virtual Environment and rpi-lgpio Install

Listing A.3: Commands used to create the python virtual environment and install rpi-lgpio.

```
1 wget http://abyz.me.uk/lg/lg.zip
2 unzip lg.zip
3 cd lg
4 make
5 sudo make install
6 python3 -m venv gpio-env
7 source gpio-env/bin/activate
8 pip install rpi-lgpio
```

A.4 GPIO Read Script

Listing A.4: Python script used to run on the Raspberry Pi to monitor one of the GPIO pins.

```
1 #!/usr/bin/env python3
2 import RPi.GPIO as GPIO # Uses rpi-lgpio backend automatically
3 from time import sleep
4 import signal
5
6 # Setup
7 GPIO_PIN = 17
8 GPIO.setmode(GPIO.BCM)
9 GPIO.setup(GPIO_PIN, GPIO.IN, pull_up_down=GPIO.PUD_DOWN)
10
11 print("Sensing 3.3V High...")
12
13 try:
14     while True:
15         if GPIO.input(GPIO_PIN):
16             print("Pin High")
17             sleep(1)
18 except KeyboardInterrupt:
19     print("Stopping...")
```

```
20 finally:
21     GPIO.cleanup()
22 pause()
```

A.5 Test Data and Logs